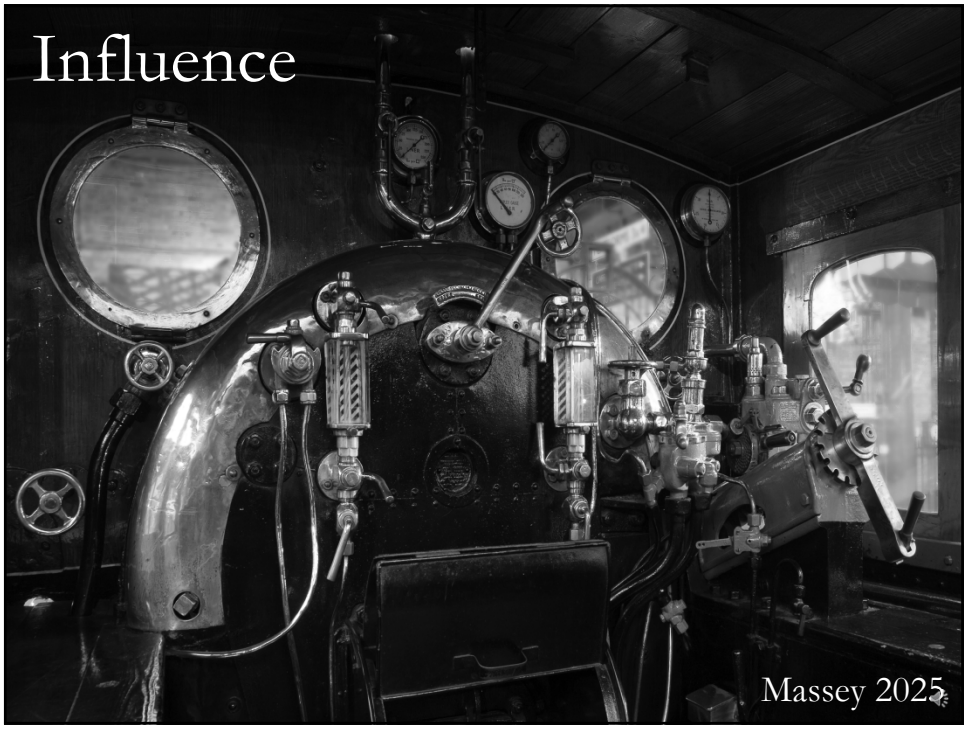


1

Today's Agenda

Course admin
Sapolsky and baboons
Status lecture & discussion

2

Course Admin (1 of 2)

Next class (capstone)

- Case: Donna Dubinsky (Study.net)
- Watch: Short scene from Lincoln
- Review: "Pope with the Humble Touch" from Class 1
- Survey: due by 8am Wednesday

Course evaluations

- Will give you 5 minutes in our final class

3

Course Admin (2 of 2)

"Make It Your Own (MIYO)" Final Project

- In short: The course concepts you want to carry forward, baked into a vehicle that will keep them alive in your life.
- Due EOD Thursday December 11
- AI policy
  - You can use AI for anything but text generation
    - Your thoughts are what matter here, and what will stay with you
  - Every project must include an AI disclosure
    - Indicate what, if anything, AI was used for
    - Even if AI was not used at all
- Prof. Massey grades all projects
  - Do not identify yourself unless you absolutely must
  - See next slide for the grading rubric

4

MIYO Grading Rubric

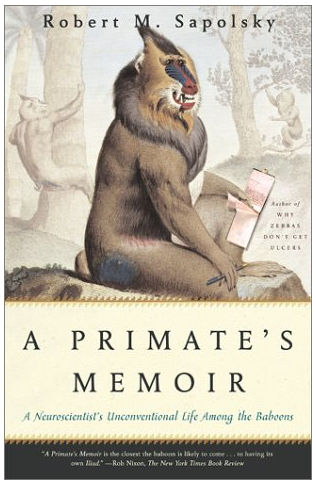
Criteria	Ratings					Pts
Relevance Project appropriately scoped in breadth and depth.	5 pts Exceptional	4 pts Very strong	3 pts Strong	2 pts Solid	1 pts Below expectations	5 pts
Insight A personal synthesis of course material; personal insights generated by working with course materials; ideas applied to your unique personal or professional context.	5 pts Exceptional	4 pts Very strong	3 pts Strong	2 pts Solid	1 pts Below expectations	5 pts
Prescriptions Concrete, actionable prescriptions, with consideration to how you can best commit yourself to them.	5 pts Exceptional	4 pts Very strong	3 pts Strong	2 pts Solid	1 pts Below expectations	5 pts
Presentation Material presented in a compelling way, drawing on course concepts where possible to maximize the impact on your future self.	5 pts Exceptional	4 pts Very strong	3 pts Strong	2 pts Solid	1 pts Below expectations	5 pts
					Total Points: 20	

5

Sapolsky, "Ch 22, The Baboons: Nick"

By studying baboons (etc.) can observe the role of status, and its effects, more directly.





6

Sapolsky, "Ch 22, The Baboons: Nick"

Physiological ramifications
- Stress hormones
- Interaction between status & stability

Benefits of status

Coalitions

Status reinforced through physical humiliation
- Submission postures
- Nick urinating on the treed baboon

Ethos (!)
- Nick claimed credit for downing Reuben

7

CORNER OFFICE

Think 'We' for Best Results

Published: April 18, 2009

***Nell Minow** is a co-founder of the Corporate Library, a provider of corporate governance research. She is a former principal of Lens, a shareholder-activist investment firm, and is a former president of Institutional Shareholder Services. This interview with Ms. Minow was conducted and condensed by **Adam Bryant**.*

Enlarge This Image



Daniel Rosenbaum for The New York Times

Nell Minow is the editor and a co-founder of the Corporate Library, a provider of corporate governance research.

Walker Prieb (WG'24): "I have directly noted that subordinates are more likely to humor their superior (in this case me). I've never been a very funny person, but when I was the senior lieutenant at my last command, far more people than normal would laugh at my poor jokes. It felt good to finally be funny (after all those years), but once I realized why they were probably laughing it was hard to unnotice."

Another thing is, the day that he left I.S.S. and left me to be president, the last thing he said to me was, "Watch how funny your jokes get."

And I must think about that three or four times a week. Not because I'm telling a joke and people are laughing, but because I need to remind myself constantly of the challenge that gets tougher and tougher as you get higher in the organization to get people to be honest with you.

8

Status, the downside



"The chief danger of status is that of suppressing personal development, and so of causing social enfeeblement, rigidity and ultimate decay."

- Park & Burgess, 1921

9



Love is people being nice to you because they like you;
power is them being nice even though they might hate you.

- Alain de Botton

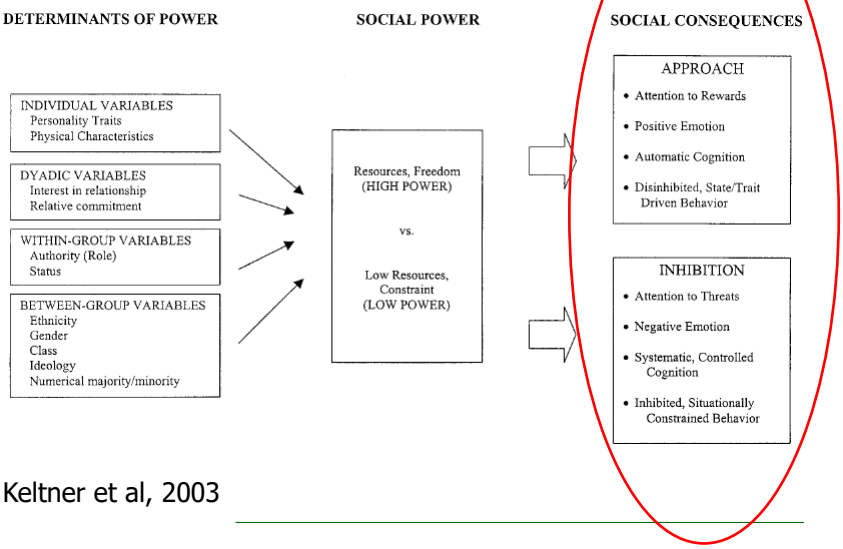
10

The Psychology of Status: Cause & Effect



11

Recent Social Psychology



Keltner et al, 2003

12

Social Consequences of Power (Keltner et al)

Elevated [reduced] power increases…

- experience and expression of positive [negative] affect
- sensitivity to rewards [threat & punishment]
- tendency to construe others as means to an end [self as means to others' ends]
- automatic [controlled] social cognition
  - e.g., stereotype usage
- approach-related behavior [behavioral inhibition]
  - e.g., food, physical space, verbal & non-verbal, sex
- consistent & coherent [situationally contingent] social behavior
- likelihood of socially inappropriate behavior
  - e.g., interrupt, speak out of turn, impolite eating

13

Themes in this literature

Power leads to…

- Empathy deficits
- Self-serving impulsivity
- Incivility and disrespect
- Narratives of exceptionalism

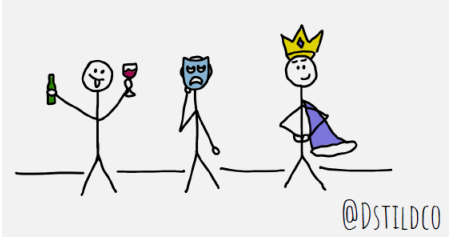
- Keltner, The Power Paradox, 2016

14

The Psychology of Power: Disinhibition

Increased power leads to acting on desires in a social context without concern for social consequences

Disinhibition is the same mechanism that tends to change behavior if drunk, or anonymous! (Hirsh, Galinsky & Zhong 2011)



15



16

TierneyLab

Putting Ideas in Science to the Test

July 1, 2009, 1:46 PM

Politicians Are Primates Too

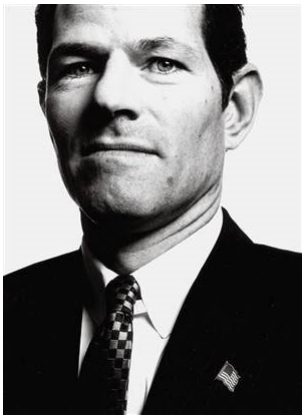
By NICHOLAS WADE

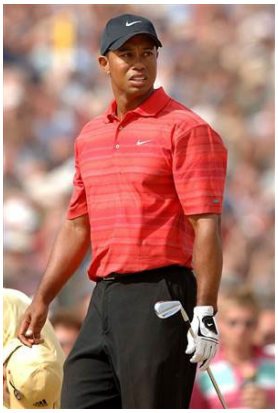


The recent travails of Senator John Ensign and Gov. Mark Sanford are another reminder of how very unfairly, from a primatological point of view, we treat our politicians.



17





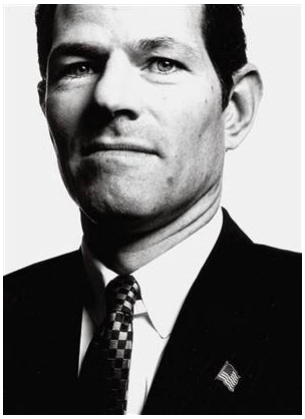
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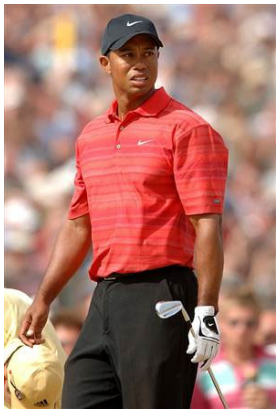
Tiger Woods

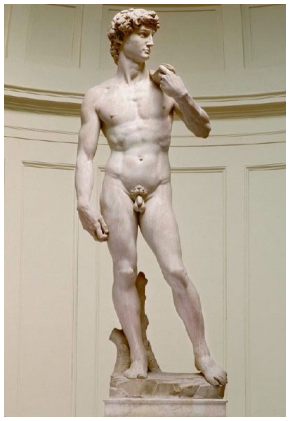
"I stopped living by the core values that I was taught to believe in. I knew my actions were wrong, but I convinced myself that normal rules didn't apply. I never thought about who I was hurting. Instead, I thought only about myself. I ran straight through the boundaries that a married couple should live by. I thought I could get away with whatever I wanted to. I felt that I had worked hard my entire life and deserved to enjoy all the temptations around me. I felt I was entitled. Thanks to money and fame, I didn't have to go far to find them."

Feb 19, 2010

19

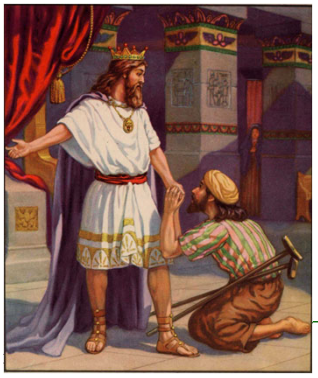
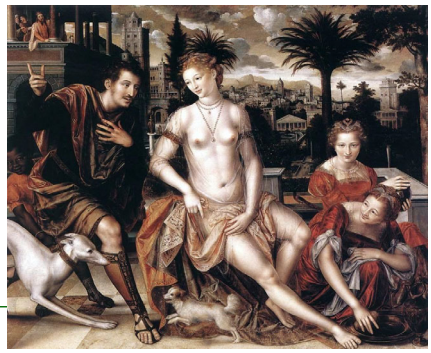






20



21

STANFORD
GRADUATE SCHOOL OF BUSINESS



Tiedens admits she gets accused of being a little evil for studying the role of hierarchies and dominant behavior—and for the recommendations she makes.

In self-defense, she says, "This sorting-out behavior is going on between people all the time, and the pernicious effects occur because we don't talk about it. Once it becomes an explicit part of a relationship, we have a lot more control over how it plays out."

22

Survey question

How does your behavior change across situations as your power changes?

23

Behavior changes due to power (8:30, randomly selected)

- "One thing I have noticed is that I less readily share my opinions when I feel I am in a less powerful situation." (Caterina Bonmassar)
- "I definitely enjoy when others praise me. I try to remember that those who are in positions of lower power than I am are likely doing it to get in my good graces, but as Kramer says, I still like to believe that there is a kernel of truth in their praise and it is hard to remain totally objective. This is true even though I know that I engage in this behavior myself when trying to ingratiate myself to those who are more powerful than I am. " (Francie Middleton)
- "I have a more dominant attitude in more powerful situations because of the ownership responsibility " (Pedro Oliveira Figueiredo Fernandes)
- "I'm much quieter when I have less social power - but also more introverted. When I'm in a group and I can tell I have a little more social power, it's comfortable for me to chat with everyone, try to have meaningful conversations and learn about others, which seems backwards." (Victoria Brown)
- "When I have more power, I may dismiss requests I see as unreasonable instead of responding with an alternative or polite decline. " (Divya Ravinder)
- "When I feel more powerful I tend to increase the level of confidence in my own abilities, which could be dangerous in the future as the amount of power / influence I have will potentially increase with a higher rank, and overconfidence can lead to more mistakes." (Maria Ramirez)
- "I often become more direct and willing to speak up when I feel powerful, and often more cautious or hesitant when I don't" (Vin Guaglardi)
- "Power makes me more confident, vocal, and proactive. Without it, I often default to observing first and speaking later." (Haley Raphael)

24

Behavior changes due to power (10:15, randomly selected)

- "When I feel powerful, I speak with sharper clarity and take charge instinctively; when I don't, I over-monitor myself and soften my presence." (Arielle Flynn)
- "I attribute value to the perks associated with status (flying business, staying in nice hotels) and can sometimes associate that with my "worth" as an employee." (Pere Puig Gonzalez)
- "I become more cautious and avoid pushing my advantage, sometimes sacrificing influence to make sure I'm not forcing anything on others." (Sid Agrawal)
- "I have noticed that when I am around people who are older, more experienced, or hold more power, I tend to step back and take a quieter role." (Caroline Sheehan)
- "I fear that I listen (intently) more when I am in less powerful situations: likely because I am doing everything I can to get to the more powerful position. It's easy to think it's not as important when you're already in the position of power." (Sydney Cheong)
- "I tend to adjust my confidence level - and therefore my projection - based on the level of expertise I have in different situations." (Carolina Nakamura Chapuis)
- "I think the more 'powerful' I get the more comfortable I am at being extremely vocal with dissenting opinions. When I have less power I am worried about social judgment when I have more power I am less concerned about this but have noticed I have less tact in sharing these opinions as my power increases. " (Ariana Katsanis)
- "I tend to share my perspective more freely when I feel like I have more/equal power relative to those in the room (e.g., colleagues who are peers or juniors vs. more senior)." (Anika Limaye)
- "When I hold power (especially if formal), I tend to feel more comfortable asserting my opinion which might make me less open to others' ideas" (Cecilia Zanna)

25

Behavior changes due to power (1:45, randomly selected)

- "My willingness to interject, disagree with others, and to take conversations in different directions" (Harry Han)
- "I tend to be more concise when I am in higher power situations. In lower power situations, I tend to overcompensate with additional words. " (Varun Varshney)
- "When I feel powerful I decide quickly / confidently, and when I don't, I hesitate more and seek extra reassurance." (Prem Patel)
- "As I move from less to more powerful situations, I find my risk-taking appetite increases. This manifests itself in a variety of ways, from increased use of humor to more comfort in pitching ideas that may be far-fetched." (Nishant Agrawal)
- "I'm much more willing to share my full point of view and propose bigger / bolder initiatives when I'm in higher power situations. " (Steven Adelberg)
- "I've definitely noticed having a slightly more nuanced view of norms as I've been in more powerful situations e.g., not having to attend company events that I don't want to, not being as strict about arriving on time. " (Louis Van De Ven)
- "The degree to which I lead or stimulate conversation changes as I move across situations. In situations where I have more power, I'm very comfortable setting the agenda, asking questions, bringing people into the conversation. In situations where I have less power, I'm much more likely to be an observer, deferring to people with more power." (Andrew Carton)
- "I always try to listen, but when I have less power I seek allies for my views, and when I have more power I seek voices that challenge me." (Ami Higuchi)
- "I notice that I air my opinions more strongly in environments where I am perceived to have more power, and listen more when I have less." (Hyun Yang)

26

Short-term vs. Long-term

Some argue that power reveals

- The greedy become more self-serving, the generous become more giving

There is definitely heterogeneity – can see it in the MBA surveys every year

But what happens when you have power for years, or decades?

27

Short-term vs. Long-term

Fundamental human nature suggest long-term could be a problem:

- Attention
  - We pay more attention to those higher status than us, as they have more control over our resources
    - Tip: Google "What's That Name? Norman the Doorman – SNL"
- Adaptation
  - We adapt to current environment as the status quo, which sets our expectations, regardless of privilege
- Feedback
  - Fewer people are willing to disagree with us, or provide honest feedback, as we have accumulate power.

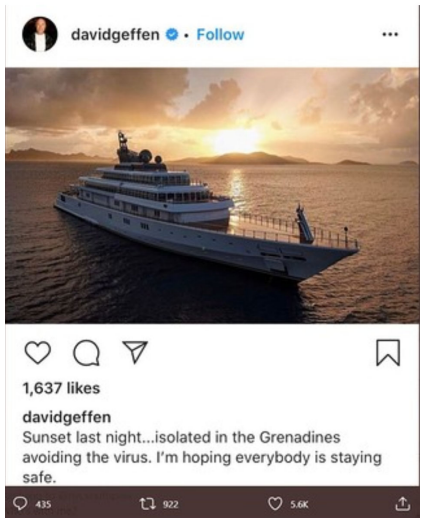
28

Jeffrey Pfeffer concurs

The combination of diminished vigilance and changed circumstances often leads to loss of power. (p211)

"No matter what the original intentions and aspiration, eventually power goes to everyone's head." (p200)

29



30

"Privilege is toxic."



Comedians in Cars Getting Coffee: "Just Tell Him You're The President" (Season 7, Episode 1)

12/2025 email from an NHL President

In the beginning—and for decades of his career—the power Robert Moses amassed was the servant of his dreams, amassed for their sake, so that his gigantic city-shaping visions could become reality. But power is not an instrument that its possessor can use with impunity. It is a drug that creates in the user a need for larger and larger dosages. And Moses was a user. At first, for a decade or more after his first sip of real power in 1924, he continued to seek it only for the sake of his dreams. But little by little there came a change. Slowly but inexorably, he began to seek power for its own sake. More and more, the criterion by which Moses selected which city-shaping public works would be built came to be not the needs of the city's people, but the increment of power a project could give him. Increasingly, the projects became not ends but means—the means of obtaining more and more power.

As the idealism faded and disappeared, its handmaidens drifted away. The principles of the Good Government reform movement which Moses had once espoused became principles to be ignored. The brilliance that had invented a civil service system was applied to the task of circumventing civil service requirements. The insistence on truth and logic was replaced by a sophistry that twisted every fact to conclusions not merely preconceived but preconceived decades earlier.

- The Power Broker, Robert Caro

"Genius-to-Folly Syndrome"

Roderick Kramer, HBR (2003), based on extensive study of business and government leaders at multiple points in their careers.

His conclusion, in short:

Expect that circumstances will change you.

33

"Genius-to-Folly Syndrome"

Kramer to his students: How will the process of attaining your achievements change you?

- "Very little", "Not at all"
- They don't expect their core values to change
- They anticipate making few trade-offs

"It is as if in finding success they will become merely bigger and better versions of what they are now."

"They can't even imagine that they could ever fall from grace. And that, of course, guarantees that some of them will."

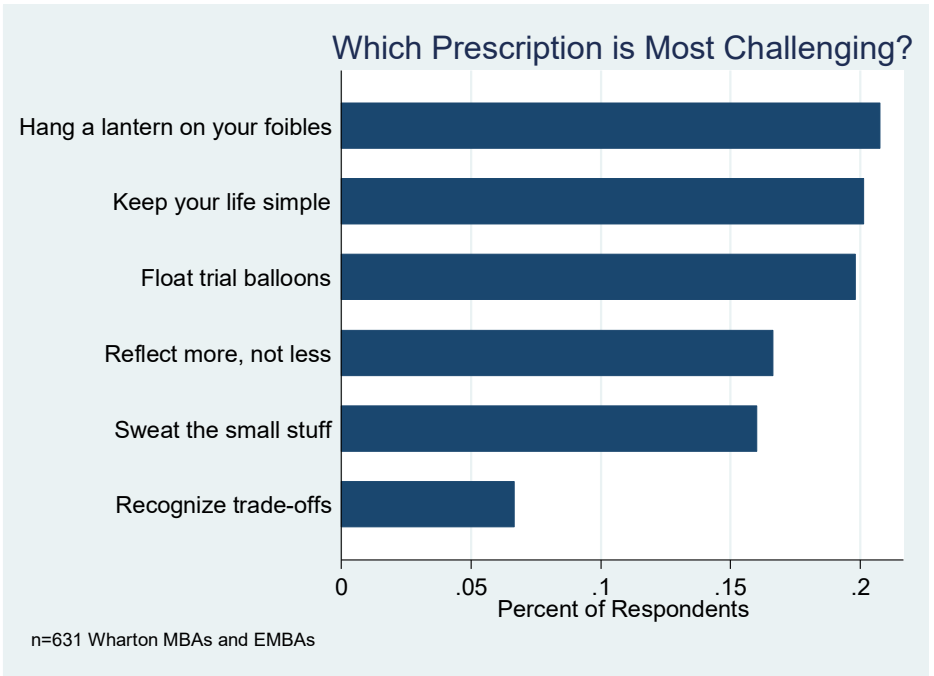
34

"Genius-to-Folly Syndrome"

Kramer's prescriptions:

- Keep your life simple
- Hang a lantern on your foibles
- Float trial balloons
- Sweat the small stuff
- Reflect more not less
- Recognize trade-offs

35



36

Recent e-mail from insurance exec*

" 'Watch how funny your jokes get.' That quote made an impression on me because it began happening once I was promoted. I am not a funny person - I don't pretend to be. My comedic timing is awful (as my wife will clearly attest to). Yet people laugh... fascinating.

"I know that as I become successful I can be lured by the temptations of reading my own press, so to speak. The slide I find most important, actually, is how to avoid "genius to folly" syndrome.

"This rings true. Every time my ego runs away with me I make a mistake. I know this and am constructing ways to integrate those points in my life for the long term. This is a real need and cannot be overstated."

* Former MBA-E student

Overall: "Remember that you are mortal"



Ancient Rome's triumphs celebrated the most successful military commanders.

By tradition, a slave sat behind the commander repeatedly saying, "Remember that you are mortal".

Proof of concept (and creative one)

Kramer's prescription to "hang a lantern on your foibles" in The Harder They Fall got me thinking about one of my old managers who had kept a log of his professional missteps for nearly five years. What's more, this manager asked his assistant to randomly select one of these errors and send it to him in the subject line of an email everyday. When I first heard of this ritual, I regarded it as very quirky, if not downright masochistic. But my manager explained that he had seen too many leaders fall prey to the "power paradox" and cease to acknowledge or learn from their errors once they reached the top. Instead, my manager was taking steps to constantly remind himself that he too was only mortal and prone to mistakes, no matter what title level or pay grade he ultimately achieved. He remarked that arrogance often led to complacency or recklessness in decision making, and vowed to do whatever he could to avoid letting hubris get the best of him as a leader.

- From a Wharton MBA 2014

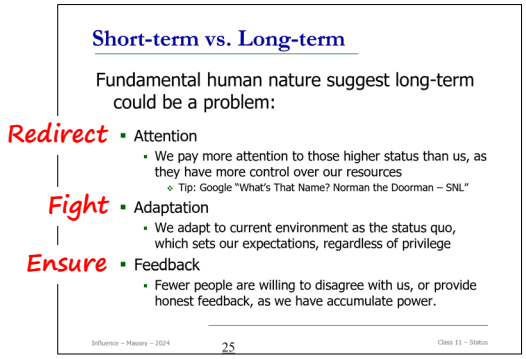
39

Breakout Groups

Discuss:

- What can you build into your regular routine that will help you avoid status traps?

But how specifically?



40

Wrap up by way of a few more prescriptions…

41

Rx #1: Don't take yourself too seriously



"Don't take yourself too seriously, and take yourself as seriously as death itself. Don't worry. Worry your ass off. Have ironclad confidence, but doubt – it keeps you awake and alert. Believe you are the baddest ass in town, and, you suck!

"It keeps you honest. Be able to keep two completely contradictory ideas alive and well inside of your heart and head at all times. If it doesn't drive you crazy, it will make you strong."

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Rx #2: Remember your good luck

"People really don't like to hear success explained away as luck — especially successful people. As they age, and succeed, people feel their success was somehow inevitable. They don't want to acknowledge the role played by accident in their lives."



Michael Lewis (Princeton alum) at Princeton commencement

One implication (via a former student):

"You're rarely as good, or as bad, as people say you are."

Rx #3: Get out of your circle

"What you have to do is every now and then expose yourself to a social circle that really doesn't care about your position." (Pfeffer, p203)



Rx #4: Treat everyone with dignity

Former (eventual) star player Max Copeland on long-time Missouri coach, Gary Pinkel:

"The first thing that stands out to me were small but powerful instances where he showed me respect, despite not being on scholarship. I'm a big believer that character is defined by how you treat people that can't do anything for you."

Note a nice feature of this Rx: You get the "opportunity" to practice it, or not, multiple times a day, every day.

- i.e., the practice (and test!) is baked into your life.

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Appendix

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Guest Speakers, Pittsburgh Penguins

Amanda Kessel

Manager, Minor League Ops;
Asst. GM, WBS Penguins



From Madison, WI
NCAA Champion and Patty Kazmaier Award winner at University of Minnesota
Team USA Olympic Gold Medalist (2018) and multi-time World Champion
Former pro player in the PHF
Joined the Penguins in 2022



Jason Spezza

Asst. GM, Pittsburgh Penguins;
GM, WBS Penguins

From Mississauga, ON
2nd overall pick in 2001 NHL Draft
19-season NHL career with Ottawa, Dallas, and Toronto
Over 1,200 NHL games played; 995 career points
Team Canada World Champion (2015)
Joined the Penguins in 2022